The Kitchen Witches

By Caroline Smith

ISOBEL: **(Pg 57)** Dolly **was** my best friend. Yep, we were as close as sisters, Dolly and I, all the time we were growing up. We spent every second together – sat next to each other in school, talked for hours on the phone, had sleep-overs. [Then . . .] our last year of high school we met Larry Biddle. What a character . . .

INTRODUCTION

Isobel Lomax and Dolly Biddle are two "mature" cable cooking show hostesses who have hated each other for 40 years. Ever since Larry Biddle dated one and married the other. Now fate has intervened and put them together on a reality TV show. Hold on to your hats, ladies and gentlemen! It's. . .

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ISOBEL (VOICE OVER): *(off-stage)* **(Pg 13-14)** Dear Babcha, I have been watching you since the other cooking show was cancelled last month. I was wondering do you know Isobel Lomax, the hostess of "Busy Izzy" and if so, can you get me her recipe for Steak and Kidney Pie?

DOLLY: *(in a decidedly fake Russian accent and smiling dangerously into the camera)* Hello, Jane dear! Of course I know that person you mention. But you sound like nice lady, so I do nice thing. I don't get you recipe for Snake and Pygmy pie. But I tell you reasons why Busy Izzy show was cancelled. One. Stupid name. Two. Stupid food. Three. Stupid woman. . . .

ISOBEL: **(Pg 14-15)** *(making her way to the sound stage)* Ha! . . . I said ha!

DOLLY: Who is . . . *(She gasps)* . . . Isobel Lomax! What on earth are you doing here?

ISOBEL: Over the past few weeks I have ben watching this . . show. I thought it time I came down in person and let you know I have had enough of this constant slander. Dolly Biddle, you have publicly insulted me for the last time. You can expect a call from my lawyer on Monday. *(starts to leave, then turns)* Does your viewing audience know that "Babcha from Ukraine" is really Dorothy Plotznik from Sudbury? *(Dolly gasps, pans for the camera and then runs off-stage to her dressing room)*

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ISOBEL: **(Pg 16-17)** *(Taking over the show)* Hello folks – Busy Izzy here! I'll just fill in for a bit – after all, that's what bosom buddies are for! Now let's just clear off our counter and start fresh. *(She dumps all of Dolly's cooking into the garbage can)* We'll start by making Izzy's Perfect Shortcrust Pastry. *(begins preparation)* Our friend Babcha is really Dolly Biddle, and she was born, not far, far away in the Ukraine but in beautiful downtown Sudbury! How do I know this? Why we grew up together, Dolly and I!

DOLLY: *(Emerging from her dressing room without her accent)* What do you think you're doing?

ISOBEL: She was Dorothy Plotznick. Biddle is her married name . . .

DOLLY: At least I go married! At least I had a husband.

ISOBEL: You know perfectly well I dated Larry Biddle first.

DOLLY: In your dreams! I was going steady with Larry long before you oozed onto the scene! Who did he take to the Senior Prom, huh?

ISOBEL: Well, Larry may have married you, but I was the one who made him happy!

DOLLY: That man was never happy!

ISOBEL: How could he be living with you? *(pointing with her ring hand)*

DOLLY: What is that? *(Isobel holds up her hand, showing off a flashy ring)*

ISOBEL: What – this?

DOLLY: That's . . . that's the Biddle family heirloom ring!

ISOBEL: Larry gave it to me when we were dating.

DOLLY: He told me he lost it! That ring should be mine!

ISOBEL: You can pry this from my cold, dead hand!

DOLLY: *(Picking up a chopping knife)* Fine by me! *(then notices the cameras are still running)* **(Pg 19)** *(resumes her poise and In her Russian accent)* Well, it's been so nice sharing time with you each week, peoples, and Babcha is so sorry to say goodbye. So – everybodys . . . remember to eat good, enjoy life and most important . . wash your hands! This is Babcha . .

ISOBEL: *(Butting into the camera range)* And Busy Izzy!

DOLLY: Saying goodbye!

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ISOBEL: And good cooking! *(Both wave to the camera until the audience is "gone" – Then the two glare at each other as a phone rings – Dolly picks it up)*

DOLLY: **(Pg 21)** *(Still in a Russian accent)* Hello? *(to Isobel)* It's the Elm Street Bridge Club . . . *(listens)* Really? You did? What? *(to Isobel as she hangs up the phone)* They say that was the funniest show they've ever seen, they loved it. *(a look of shock from both ladies)*

ISOBEL: **(Pg 22)** On the air again?

DOLLY: Together?

ISOBEL: We can't share a show – within five minutes one of us would be dead . . .

DOLLY: And the other charged with murder! We've hated each other almost forty years!

ISOBEL: Well, it's a ridiculous idea. I have no intention of continuing to air my personal affairs in public.

DOLLY: *(laughing)* You've always opened your big fat cakehole to anyone who would listen!

ISOBEL: That is an outright lie! I am an extremely private person!

DOLLY: Ha! You're about as private as Madonna's cleavage. *(Pause as both contemplate a future show together)* **(Pg 23-24)** Let's try it.

ISOBEL: Count me in! The Izzy and Dolly Show!

DOLLY: You mean the Dolly and Izzy show.

ISOBEL: Why should you get first billing?

DOLLY: It's always alphabetical.

ISOBEL: *(Pouts in frustration then a has an idea)* . . . [How about] Kitchen Witches!

DOLLY: Oh, I don't think you can describe me as a witch . . .

ISOBEL: Unless you spell it with a "B" . . . **(Pg 34)** "Good morning everyone and welcome to the Kitchen Witches Show." *(shakes her head)* That's pretty bland. *(In a "wicked witch" voice)* A witchy welcome to one and all!

DOLLY: Oh, that **is** better – although I think it would be stronger if we both said it!

ISOBEL: A witchy welcome to one and all!

DOLLY: And we could cackle a little . . . *(they do)*

ISOBEL: And how about if we had a cauldron here on the counter, kind of smoking . . .

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DOLLY: Ooo, yes!

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VOICE OVER - ISOBEL: **(Pg 38)** *(Off-stage)* Your Community Service Station is proud to present the premiere broadcast of . . . The Kitchen Witches!

(Jingle - See link for a sample "tune" to use for the jingle at the bottom of this selection or create your own)

VOICE OVER - DOLLY: Let's turn up the heat and bring this show to a boil
With two ladies who mix as well as water and oil!

VOICE OVER - ISOBEL: Now here is the twosome who'll keep you in stitches
It's Isobel and Dolly . . . The Kitchen Witches! *(Witch-like cackle)*

(Dolly enters in a Scarlett O'Hara inspired hoop skirt, Isobel is off stage)

DOLLY: *(in a bad southern accent)* Well, I declare, ain't this just the prettiest audience I've evah seen! Today we'll be doin' our salute to the Old South, an' cookin' up some mighty tasty vittles, like Burnin' of Atlanta Spare Ribs and somethin' that I like to call Rhett Butler Ham Steak!

ISOBEL: **(Pg 32)** *(offstage)* What the hell is that? I'm not wearing that!

DOLLY: **(Pg 37)** *(In a soft voice to the audience)* She won't have a choice. While she was in the shower, I swiped her clothes. *(louder so Isobel can hear)* **(Pg 38-41)** I seem to be missin' something . . . My deah friend and cooking partner! *(Isobel enters dressed as "Mammy." She is not happy at all)* Well, I declare! It's Mammy! Now, no salute to Southern Cooking would be complete without Mammy's famous Buttermilk Biscuits. She makes them so good you'll think you've just died and gone to heaven!

ISOBEL: Somebody gonna die and go straight to hell . . . *(Shakes it off and tries to make the best of things and adopt a southern accent to match)* Give me that bowl – you don't know nothin' about birthin' no biscuits! Go over there and start the chicken!

DOLLY: *(Mimes preparing chicken and hums or sings "Shortnin Bread" [see link to this song at the end of the selection] while ISOBEL continues)*

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ISOBEL: Now it is true that I make the lightest, fluffiest buttermilk biscuits you've ever tried. It's a mighty sticky dough, so make sure you remove valuable jewelry before you start. *(Isobel takes off her watch and her heirloom ring and puts the to the side)* Now. You just take a half cup of shortening . . . cut into tiny little bits . . . and rub it well into the flour mixture . . . adding a cup of buttermilk . . . until you have a sticky mass of dough . . . *(to Dolly)* Will you please shut up!!!!!

DOLLY: *(continuing with her chicken preparations)* Well! Wait 'til I tell Rhett about this!

ISOBEL: Frankly, my dear, I don't give a damn!!

DOLLY: Well, I nevah! I'll thank you to keep a civil tongue in your head and get back to your biscuits, Mammy!

ISOBEL: To hell with the biscuits! I am not your Mammy and I refuse to continue this ridiculous charade! I did not study at the Cordon Blue for four years just to end up on a tacky show, wearing an offensive costume and being made a fool of by some overstuffed Atlanta bell!

DOLLY: *(Whisking her marinade) Who* are you calling overstuffed?

ISOBEL: Honey, we could fill you with helium and rename you Zeppelin! **(Pg 45-47)** *(notices they are still on air and becomes instantly cheery again)* Oh! Is it viewer mail time already?

DOLLY: Time goes to quickly on the show, doesn't it. Alright! Let's check our cauldron for viewer mail.

ISOBEL: Hubble bubble, snow and hail
Show us lots of witchy mail!

DOLLY: Toil and trouble, hail and snow,
Tell us what you want to know!

ISOBEL: One, two . . . three! *(They each pull out a letter)*

DOLLY: Would you like to go first, Izzy dear?

ISOBEL: No, dear – after you.

DOLLY: All right. This is a letter from Lucy. She writes

ISOBEL (as Lucy): Dear Kitchen Witches, you have so many interesting recipes – are there any plans for a cookbook? Yours witchily, Lucy M.

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DOLLY: Lucy, we have wonderful news for you. We have just signed on with Edibles Publishing. The Kitchen Witches Cookbook is going to be available everywhere by Thanksgiving! *(Dolly suddenly winces in pain and holds her stomach – She passes gas loudly)*

ISOBEL: *(embarrassed)* What's the matter with you? We can discuss the cookbook later.

DOLLY: You bet your ass. . . paragus we will. I just had too much prime rib last night . . . my tummy's a little unsettled . . . *(another great poof of air)*

ISOBEL: Great *(panning for the camera)* I'm working with Emeril LeGassy.

DOLLY: It'll pass in a minute.

ISOBEL: ell don't pass it over here! *(Dolly continues to struggle and pass gas loudly)* Don't get too close. The woman is powered by methane.

DOLLY: This is all your fault!

ISOBEL: My fault? Nonsense! If you didn't snack constantly, you wouldn't have all these digestive upsets! *(Pans to the camera again)* **(Pg 31)** It's hard to soar like an eagle when you work with a turkey.

DOLLY: *(escalating quickly – she goes nose-to-nose with Isobel)* Who are you calling a turkey, you scrawny-necked buzzard?

ISOBEL: **(Pg 39)** Why don't you go take a flying f . . . idle dee-dee! *(then realizes they are still on air)* **(Pg 41)** It's time we admitted that his was a bad idea from the beginning! We were fools to think it could ever work. Sorry to disappoint you folks, but this show has just been cancelled! *(Isobel storms off stage)*

DOLLY: *(Passes gas loudly – an ending exclamation point)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Caroline Smith
ISBN: 978-0573632860
Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): Nov 2012

AWARD HISTORY

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Shortnin' Bread music and lyrics: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4v5rsEa9vUI

Sample tune to use for the Kitchen Witch jingle: https://soundcloud.com/chrisrenfro/sets/the-kitchen-witches

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